

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In order to prevent nonnative fish species from moving freely between the Mediterranean and Red Seas, marine biologist Bella Galil has proposed that a saline lock system be installed along the Suez Canal in Egypt’s Great Bitter Lakes. The lock would increase the salinity of the lakes and _____ a natural barrier of water most marine creatures would be unable to cross.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. creates
- B. create
- C. creating
- D. created

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of non-finite (untensed) verb forms in a sentence. The modal “would,” which indicates the future from a perspective in the past, should be accompanied by a non-finite plain form verb. In this choice, the non-finite plain form verb “create” is used correctly in conjunction with the non-finite plain form verb “increase” to describe what the lock would do.

Choice A is incorrect because the finite present tense verb “creates” can’t be used in this way with the modal “would” to describe what the lock would do. Choice C is incorrect because the present participle “creating” can’t be used in this way with the modal “would” to describe what the lock would do. Choice D is incorrect because the finite past tense verb “created” can’t be used in this way with the modal “would” to describe what the lock would do.